

Sean Rutherford McEwan

Bingham Hall 2014, The University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill

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Research Interests

Race and technology; algorithmic discrimination and platform governance; critical and cultural studies of digital media; political economy of platforms; internet culture; media history and theory.

Education

- 2026** **Ph.D.**, University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill (*in progress; scheduled 2027*)
Communication
Dissertation: *White By Code*.
Advisor: Aaron Shapiro
Committee: Sharon Holland, Armond Towns, Alice Marwick, Kumi Silva, Torin Monahan
- 2019** **M.A.**, University of Illinois at Chicago
Communication
Advisor: Adrienne Massanari
Committee: Zizi Papacharissi and Andrew Rojecki
- 2016** **B.A.**, Honours (First Class), University of Western Australia
History and Cultural Studies

Publications

Refereed Journal Articles

McEwan, S. Rutherford. "Nation of Shitposters: Ironic Engagement with the Facebook Posts of Shannon Noll as Reconfiguration of an Australian National Identity." *Platform Journal of Media and Communication* 8, no. 2 (2017). [PDF](#)

Refereed Conference Proceedings

McEwan, S. Rutherford. "Stuff (Is Something) White People Like: On the White Prototypicality of Facebook." *AoIR Selected Papers of Internet Research*, February 4, 2025. [doi](#).

McEwan, S. Rutherford. "'This Meme Is What We Call Progress': History-as-Meme, Meme-as-History on 4chan." *AoIR Selected Papers of Internet Research*, February 2, 2020. [doi](#).

Papers Under Review

McEwan, S. Rutherford, and Foster, M. N. "(Tres)Passing: On the Strange Career of Jessica Krug." Revise and resubmit, *Howard Journal of Communications*.

McEwan, S. Rutherford. "Diversity and Exclusion: Facebook's 'Ethnic Affinity' as Postracial Technology." Under review, *Cultural Studies*.

McEwan, S. Rutherford. "Black Fantasies: Heidegger, Corpses, *Ge-Stell*, History." Under review, *Graduate Faculty Philosophy Journal*.

Grants and Funding

- 2025** UNC Chapel Hill, Dissertation Completion Fellowship. \$22,000.
- 2024** UNC Chapel Hill, Graduate Student Transportation Grant. \$1,200.
UNC Chapel Hill, Graduate Student Council Travel Award. \$400.
- 2023** UNC Chapel Hill, Graduate Student Council Travel Award. \$400.
- 2019** UNC Chapel Hill, Monroe and Rebecca Cobey Fellow. \$25,000 over five years.
UNC Chapel Hill, Doctoral Merit Assistantship. \$20,000.
- 2018** University of Illinois at Chicago, Graduate Student Council Travel Award. \$150.

Awards and Honours

- 2025** Media Aesthetics VII: Excluded Media, Centre for Global Culture and Communication, Northwestern University (*selected participant*)
UNC Chapel Hill, Stojakovic/van Lidth de Jeude Award for Collegiality
UNC Chapel Hill, Boka W. Hadzija Award for Distinguished University Service (*nominee*)
- 2024** National Communication Association Convention, Top Student Paper, Critical and Cultural Studies Division
UNC Chapel Hill, Outstanding Achievement in Service and Leadership
- 2023** Association of Internet Researchers Doctoral Colloquium, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania (*selected participant*)
- 2019** University of Illinois at Chicago, National Communication Association Award
- 2018** University of Illinois at Chicago, Department of Communication Student Presenter Award

Conference Activity

Presentations

- 2026** "What Was the Anti-Racist Reading List?" Paper accepted for the **National Communication Association Convention**, New Orleans, Louisiana, November 19–22, 2026.
- "Backward-Looking, Foolhardy and Fantastique: Against the New Luddism" Paper accepted for the **Union for Democratic Communications**, Ithaca, New York, October 22–24, 2026.
- "Seizing the Means of Computation: On AI and Craftwork" Paper accepted for the **Union for Democratic Communications**, Ithaca, New York, October 22–24, 2026.
- "From Content Mines to Bread Lines: 'Clanker' and the Performance of Anti-AI Sentiment in Precarious Cultural Production" Paper accepted for the **Association of Internet Researchers Conference**, Mexico City, Mexico, October 14–17, 2026.
- "Kick Out the Spams: AI and the Creator Economy." Paper presented at the **Cultural Studies Association Conference**, May 28–30, 2026.

- "40 Acres and a Tool: A Manifesto for Media (of) Reconstruction." Paper presented at the **Society for Cinema and Media Studies Conference**, Chicago, Illinois, March 26–29, 2026.
- 2025** "Go Tell it on the Paramount Plus: Genre, Vigilantism, and Bureaucracy in Post-COVID Prestige Television." Paper presented at the **National Communication Association Convention**, Denver, Colorado, November 20–23, 2025.
- "Hanging Out in the Virtual Mall: Prolegomenon to a Discussion of the Suburbanisation of the Internet." Paper presented at the **Union for Democratic Communications**, Tacoma, Washington, June 19–22, 2025.
- "How Do You Measure a Year in the Life of a Platform? On the Importance of Adopting a More Clearly Antagonistic Relationship to Digital Rentiers." Paper presented at the **Union for Democratic Communications**, Tacoma, Washington, June 19–22, 2025.
- 2024** McEwan, S. Rutherford, and Foster, M. N. "(Tres)Passing: Facsimile Blackness as Racial Technology." Top Student Paper, Critical and Cultural Studies Division, **National Communication Association Convention**, New Orleans, Louisiana, November 21–24, 2024.
- "'The Title Must Exist Before It Can Be Sold': The Shared Heritage of Facebook and Malls as Usufructaries." Paper presented at the **National Communication Association Convention**, New Orleans, Louisiana, November 21–24, 2024.
- "Whiteness of a Different Code: Facebook, Ethnic Affinity, and Housing Discrimination." Paper presented at the **National Communication Association Convention**, New Orleans, Louisiana, November 21–24, 2024.
- "'Stuff (is something) White People Like': On the White Prototypicality of Facebook." Paper presented at the **Association of Internet Researchers Conference**, Sheffield, England, October 30–November 2, 2024.
- "Going Electric: Bringing Media Back Home to Cultural Studies." Paper presented at the **Cultural Studies Association Conference**, Savannah, Georgia, May 30–June 1, 2024.
- 2023** "Academics of the World, Unite! We Have Nothing To Lose But Our Grant Applications!" Paper presented at the **Post-API Conference**, Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, October 22, 2023.
- McEwan, S. Rutherford, and Foster, M. N. "The Unbearable Whiteness of Being: The Strange Career of Jessica Krug." Paper presented at the **Cultural Studies Association Conference**, Fairfax, Virginia, June 1–5, 2023.
- 2021** McEwan, S. Rutherford, and Scalzetti, J. "What Is This 'Alternative' in Alternative Right? Old Reaction, New Media." Paper presented virtually at the **Cultural Studies Association Conference**, June 10–12, 2021.
- 2020** "'DO IT AGAIN, BOMBER HARRIS': On Digital Eichmanns, Reaping the Whirlwind, and the Possibility of Historical Empathy on 4chan." Paper presented virtually at the **Cultural Studies Association Conference**, Chicago, Illinois, May 28–30, 2020.
- 2018** "Where Saving Power Is, Grows the Danger Also: Reading the Limits of Heidegger's *The Question Concerning Technology* through 4chan and Facebook." Paper presented at the **National Communication Association Convention**, Salt Lake City, Utah,

November 8–11, 2018.

"'This Meme Is What We Call Progress': History-as-Meme, Meme-as-History on 4chan." Paper presented at the **Association of Internet Researchers Conference**, Montreal, Quebec, October 10–13, 2018.

"The White Wizard's Burden, or: Harry Potter and the Civilising Mission." Paper presented at the **Midwest Popular and American Culture Conference**, Indianapolis, Indiana, October 4–7, 2018.

- 2017** "Nation of Shitposters: Ironic Engagement with the Facebook Posts of Shannon Noll as an Australian Collective Identity." Paper presented at the **Australian and New Zealand Communication Association (ANZCA) Conference**, Sydney, New South Wales, July 4–7, 2017.

Moderator

- 2026** "AI & Culture 2: AI and Politics." Panel moderated at the **Southwest Popular/American Culture Association Summer Salon**, June 25–27, 2026.

Respondent

- 2024** "Ways of Seeing Life and Death Through Rhetorical Objects." Panel discussion at the **National Communication Association Convention**, New Orleans, Louisiana, November 21–24, 2024.

Panel Member

- 2018** "Perspectives on Non-use: Playing Both Sides of the Digital Divide." Panel discussion at the **National Communication Association Convention**, Salt Lake City, Utah, November 8–11, 2018.

Campus Talks

- 2025** "Paradigms of Safety in Australian Media Governance." Florida State University, November 2025.
- 2024** "Diversity and Exclusion: Facebook and the Production of Racial Difference." "Comm Day," UNC Chapel Hill Department of Communication, April 2024.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Fellow (Instructor of Record), UNC Chapel Hill **2020–2026**

COMM 450 Popular Culture

COMM 412 Critical Theory

COMM 170 Introduction to Rhetoric

COMM 140 Introduction to Media Theory, History and Criticism (6 semesters)

COMM 100 Communication & Social Processes

Teaching Assistant, UNC Chapel Hill **2019–2026**

COMM 355 Terrorism and Political Violence

COMM 325 Organisational Communication

COMM 170 Introduction to Rhetoric

COMM 140 Introduction to Media Theory, History and Criticism (3 semesters)
COMM 120 Interpersonal and Organisational Communication
COMM 113 Public Speaking
COMM 100 Communication & Social Processes (2 semesters)

Teaching Assistant, University of Illinois at Chicago **2017–2019**

COMM 301 Communication Research Methods (2 semesters)
COMM 104 Interpersonal Communication (3 semesters)
COMM 102 Introduction to Media (3 semesters)
COMM 100 Introduction to Communication (2 semesters)

Service to the Profession

Reviewer

National Communication Association; Association of Internet Researchers

University Service

Resource Director **2020–2025**

UNC Chapel Hill Communication Graduate Student Association

Responsible for constructing and maintaining student support infrastructure: the GSA website, new student orientation materials, annotated bibliographies, research guides, a repository of syllabi, and opportunities for professional development.

Zotero Workshop Organiser **2022–2026**

UNC Chapel Hill Communication Department

Run a semiannual workshop on the reference manager Zotero, covering setup and installation, common use cases, organising literature through collections and tagging, and extensions for advanced users.

Administrator **2025–2026**

University Press Sales Bot

Designed, deployed, and maintain a Bluesky bot that automatically reposts sales announcements from university presses.

Administrator **2025–2026**

Communication Job Market Spreadsheet (26-27, 25-26)

Designed, deployed, and maintain a public-facing collation of job postings.

Administrator **2026**

Communication Job Market Placement Data Spreadsheet

Designed and deployed a placement-data resource for the field to solicit data on academic hires.

Languages and Technical Skills

German. Intermediate reading and writing.
HTML, Nunjucks, CSS, JavaScript. Basic.

Professional Memberships and Affiliations

2024–2026 Coalition for Independent Technology Research

Society for Cinema and Media Studies

2023–2026 Organisation Research Group (ORG)

2021–2026 Graduate Student Affiliate, Centre for Information, Technology and Public Life (CITAP)

2018–2026 National Communication Association

Association of Internet Researchers

Cultural Studies Association